

runs at a strike rate of 200, transcended the bowling-friendly conditions to emerge as a cut above the rest. But the swashbuckling left-hander's brilliance was a double-edged sword in some ways, as it glossed over India's middle-order muddle.

In a batting lineup already disrupted after Shubman Gill's return to the format, which resulted in Sanju Samson's demotion, the team management's emphasis on flexibility added to the confusion.

Flexibility or confusion?

Samson was promoted to No. 3 against Oman due to a lack of crease time, batted at No. 5 three times in the tournament, but was inexplicably pushed down to No. 8, below Axar Patel, against Bangladesh. Suryakumar, who dropped himself to No. 11 against Oman to give his teammates batting practice, in hindsight needed time in the middle more than anyone after a woeful run of form, which saw the skipper eke

out 72 runs in six innings at an average of 18.

The move to bump up Shivam Dube at No. 3 to counter Bangladesh's spinners didn't reap rewards, and Abhishek's departure in the 12th over in that game resulted in a spectacular slowdown, with only 56 runs coming in the remaining 53 balls.

Abhishek almost single-handedly carried India's batting on his young shoulders, until Tilak Varma and Dube stepped up in the final. Tilak, though, didn't bat at his preferred No. 3 spot even once, although he has two T20I hundreds in the past year in that position.

Depth vs specialists

Despite the musical chairs with the middle order, India was unscathed in the Asia Cup. However, the likes of England, Australia and South Africa may not offer room for similar experimentation at the T20 World



Top Run-Scorers

Abhishek Sharma (India) — 314 runs in 7 matches | SR: 200.00

Pathum Nissanka (Sri Lanka) — 261 runs in 6 matches | SR: 160.12

Sahibzada Farhan (Pakistan) — 217 runs in 7 matches | SR: 116.04

Tilak Varma (India) — 213 runs in 7 matches | SR: 131.48

Fakhar Zaman (Pakistan) — 181 runs in 7 matches | SR: 120.66



Purple patch: Abhishek finished as the Asia Cup's leading run-scorer, amassing 314 runs in seven innings, highlighted by three consecutive half-centuries before the final. AP